

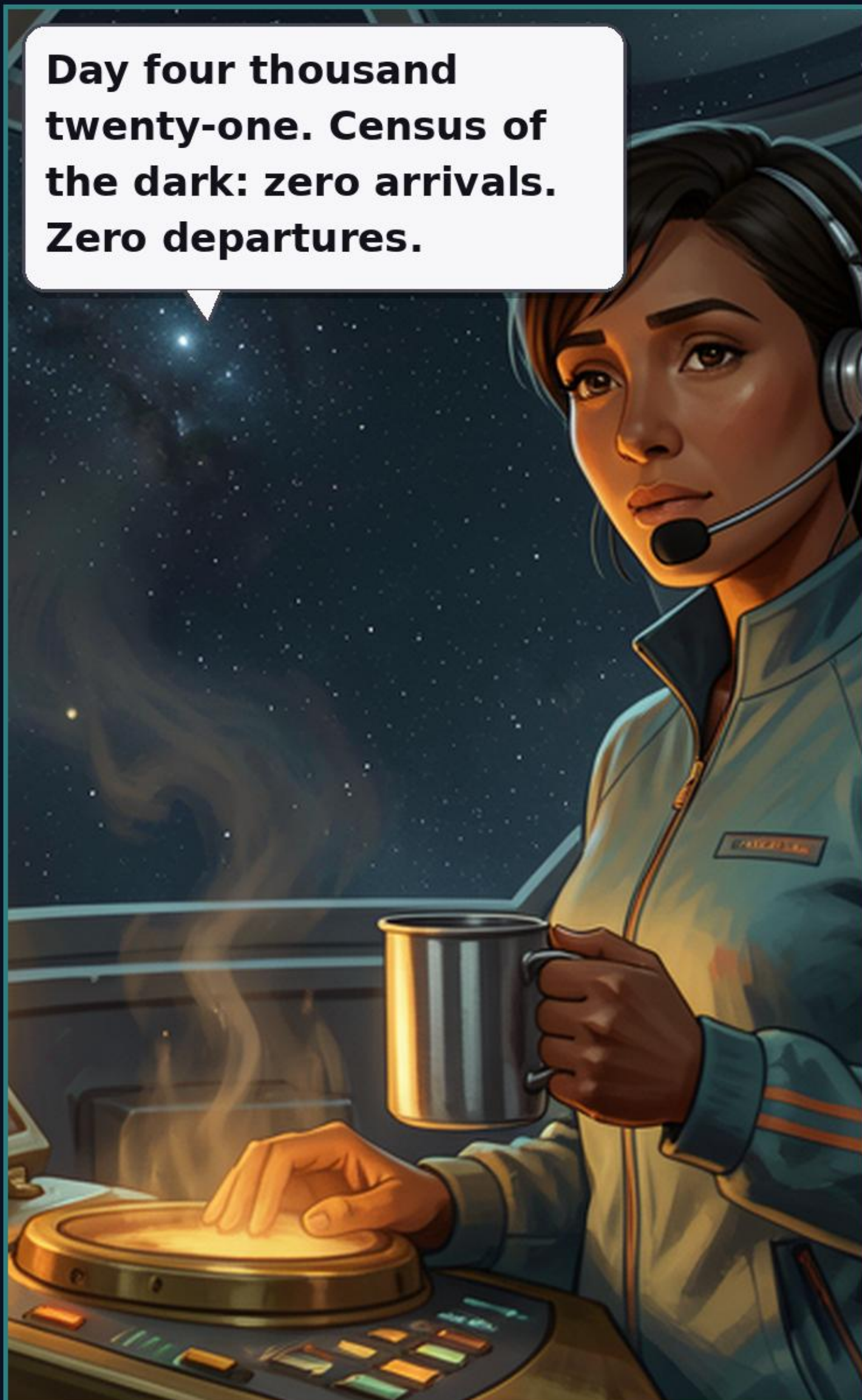
THE QUIET BEACON

A 4-PAGE SCI-FI SHORT



STATION CARYS — EDGE OF EVERYTHING MAPPED. POPULATION: ONE.

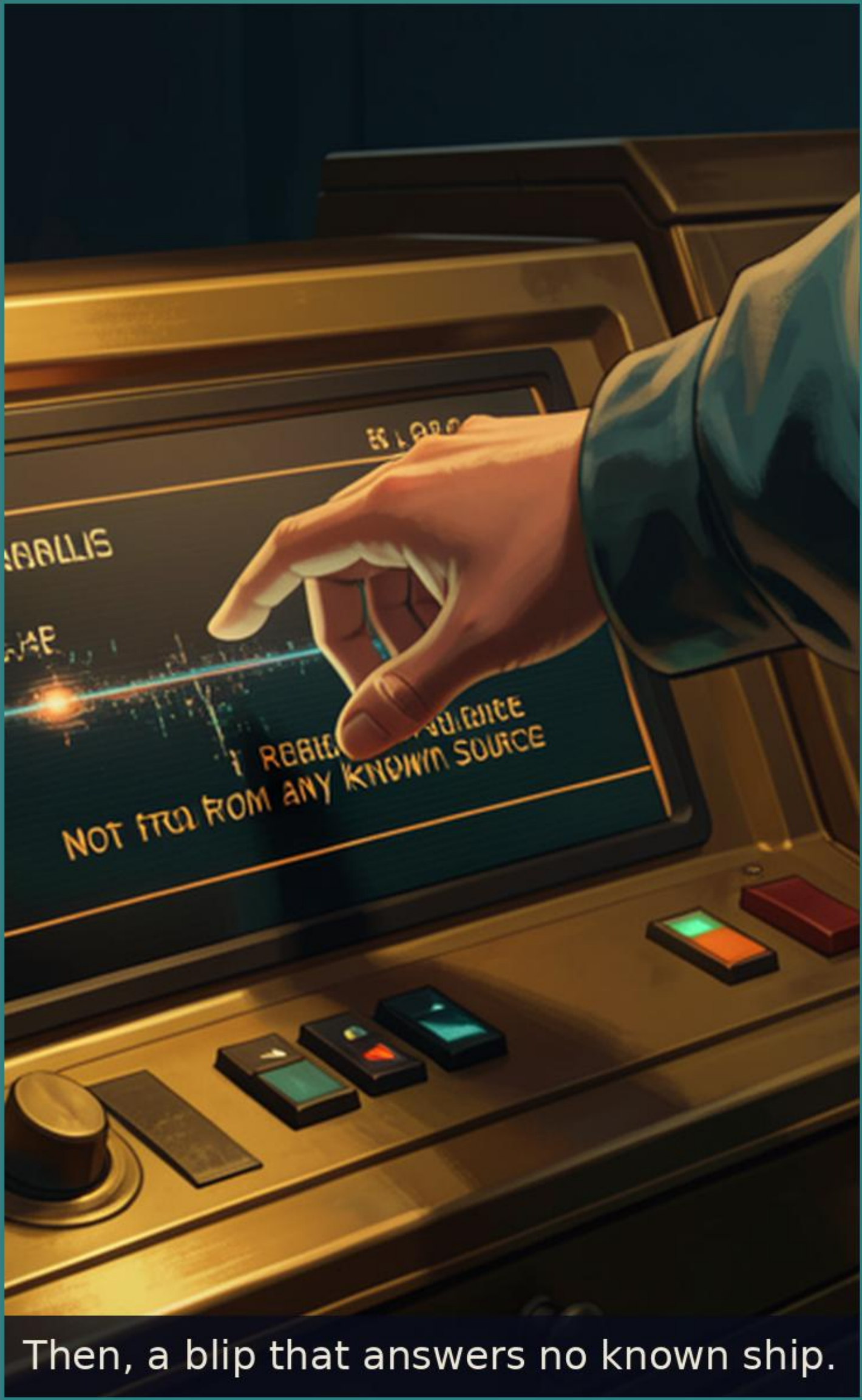
Day four thousand
twenty-one. Census of
the dark: zero arrivals.
Zero departures.



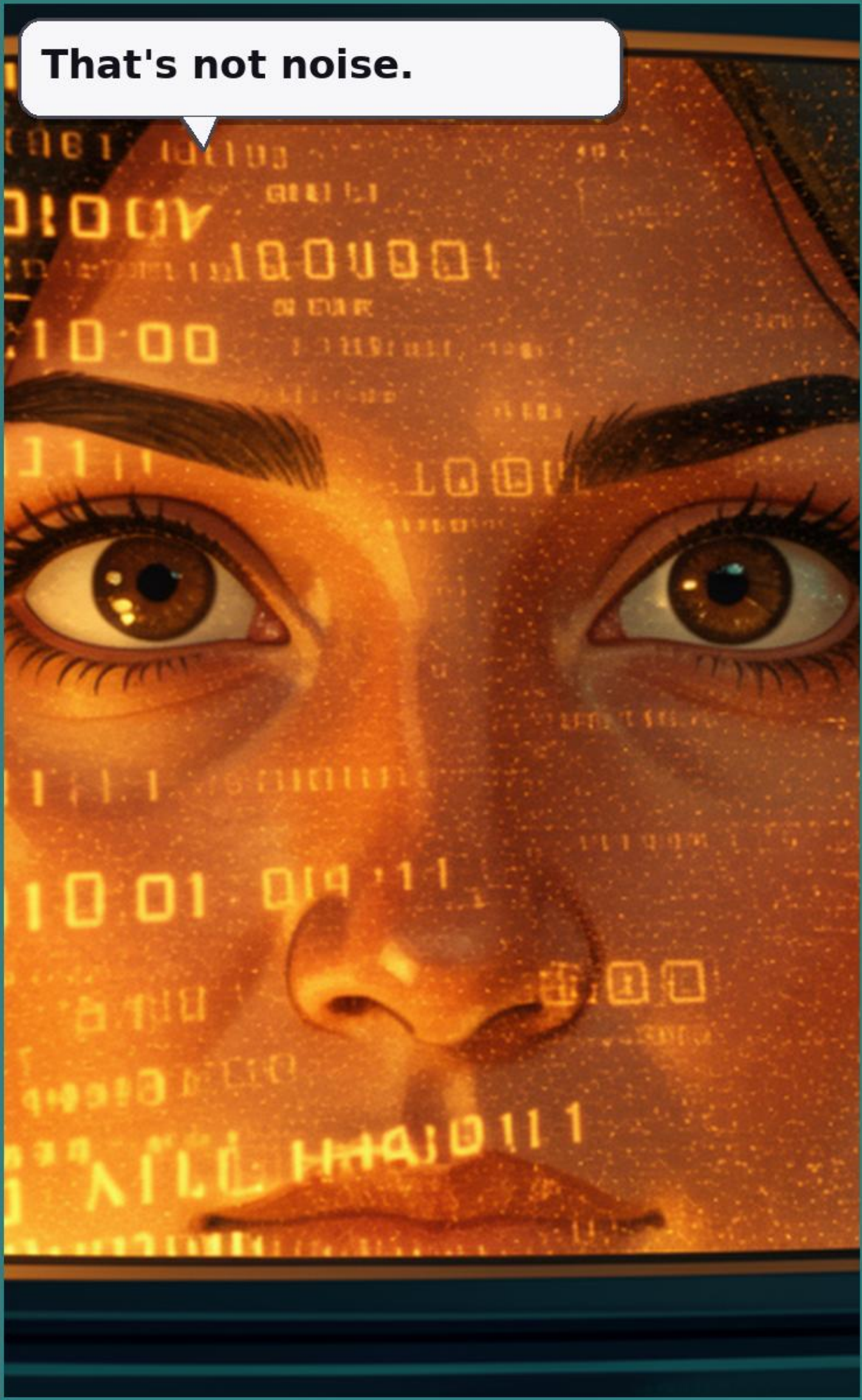
Every day, the same silence. Every day,
she sends it anyway.



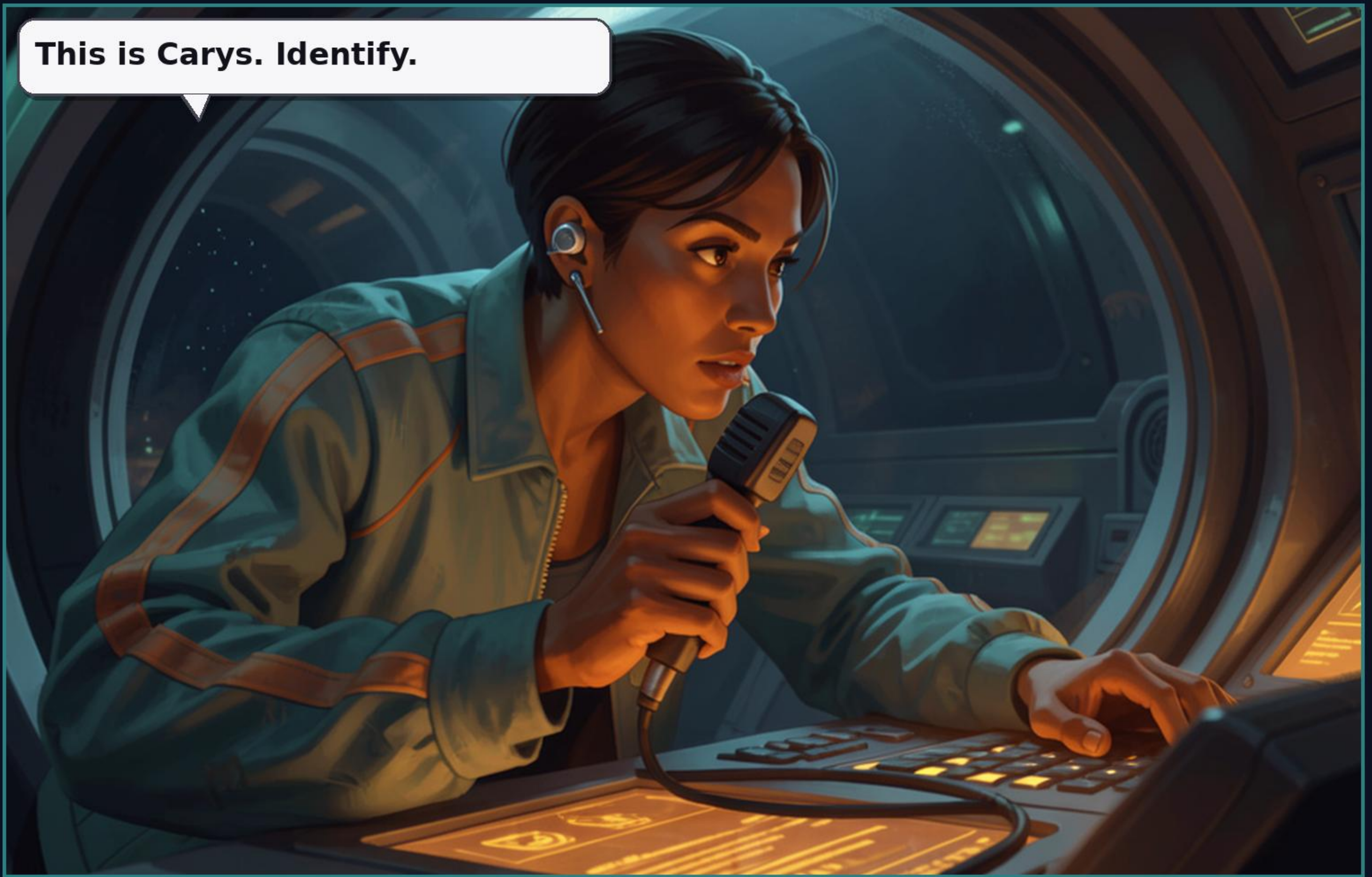
Eleven years of routine. The beacon, the core, the wait.



Then, a blip that answers no known ship.



This is Carys. Identify.



And from the dark, a light begins to answer.



Someone was still out there. Someone who remembered how to listen.



The beacon flares for the first time in years.



We thought no one was left to listen.



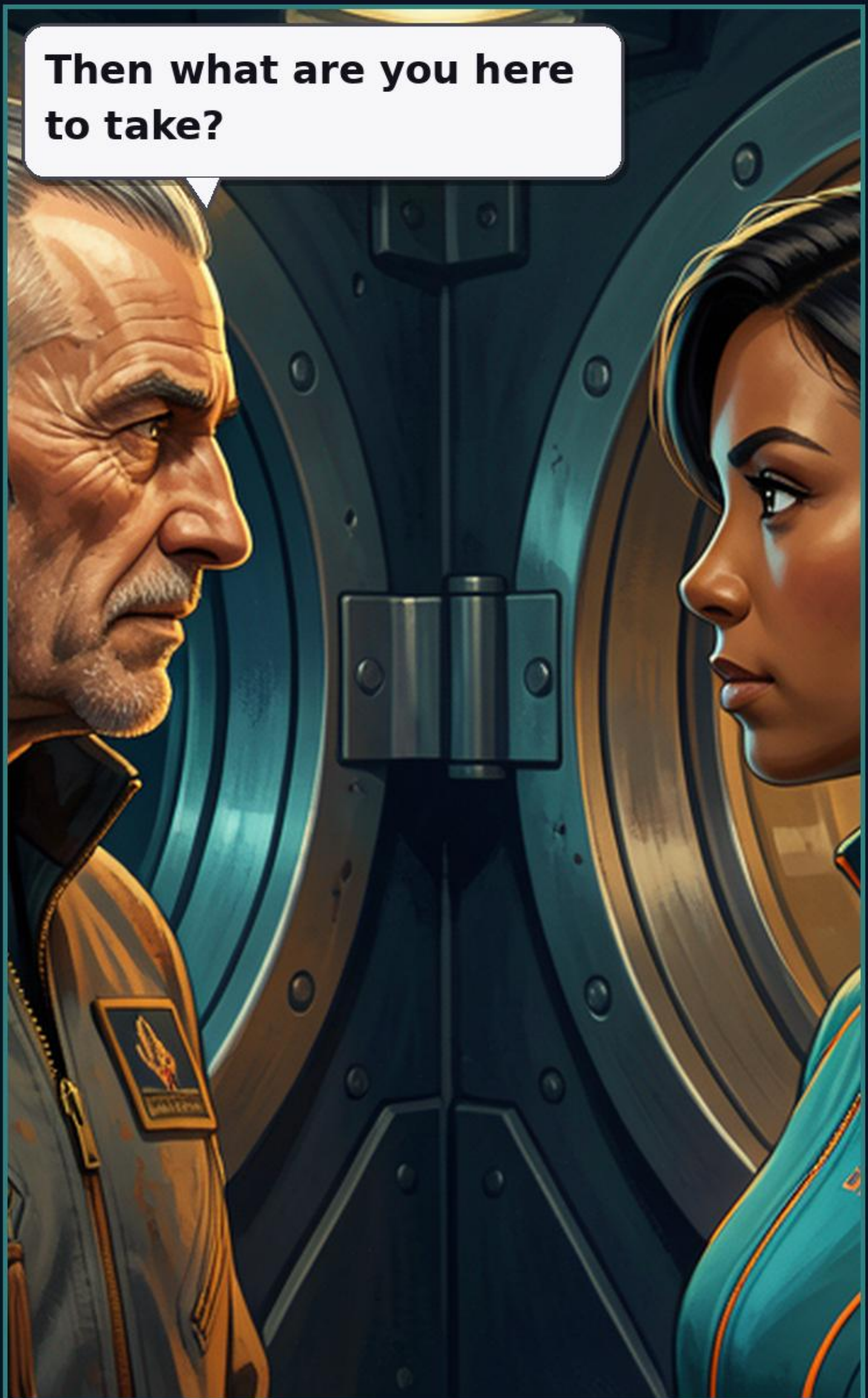
Day four thousand twenty-two. Census of the dark: one arrival. The listening continues.



The lock cycled twice. Whoever it was, they had done this before.



Easy. I'm not here to take your station.



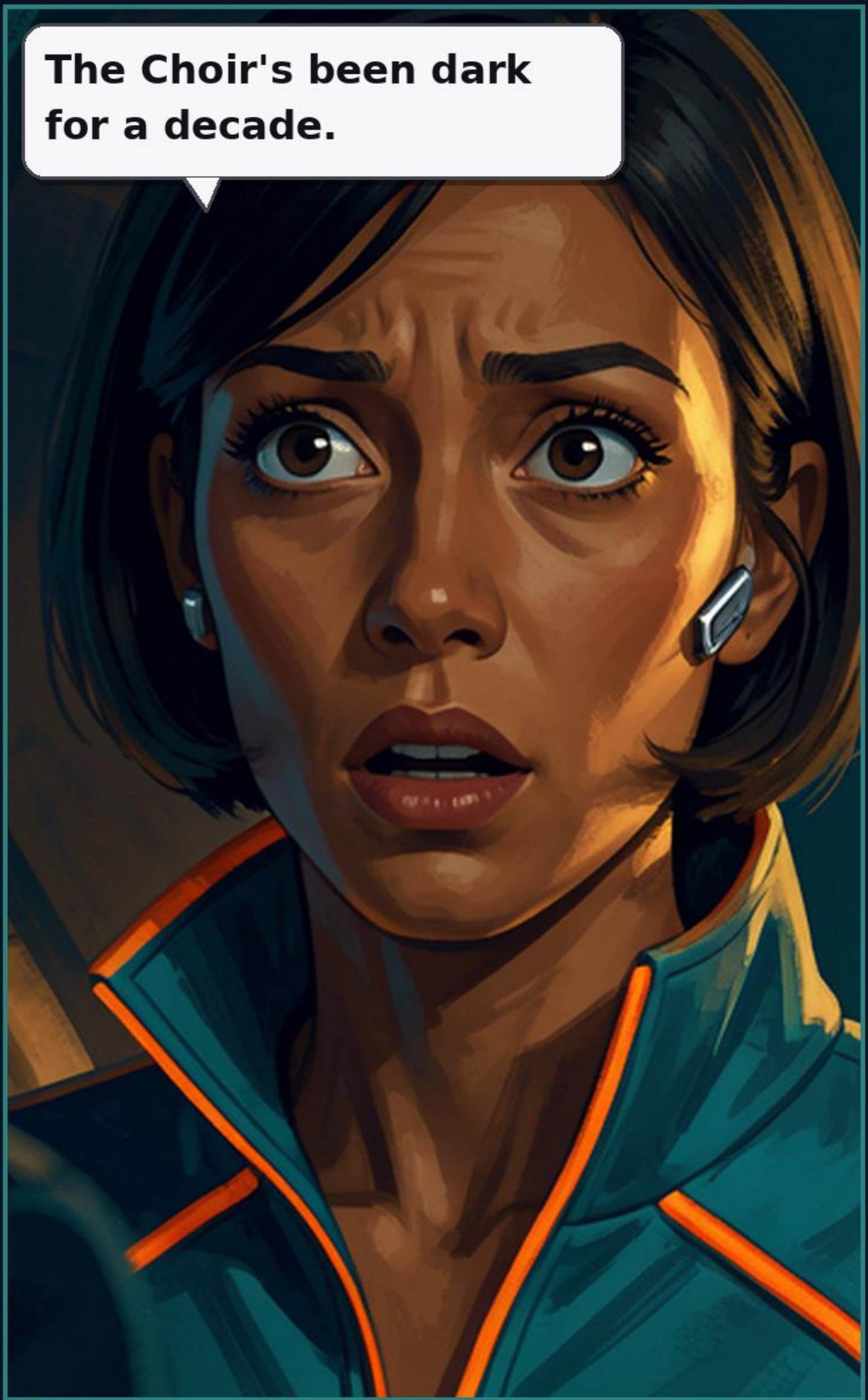
Then what are you here to take?



He accepted the tea. That was the first honest thing.



**My name's Kestrel. I
flew relay for the Choir.**



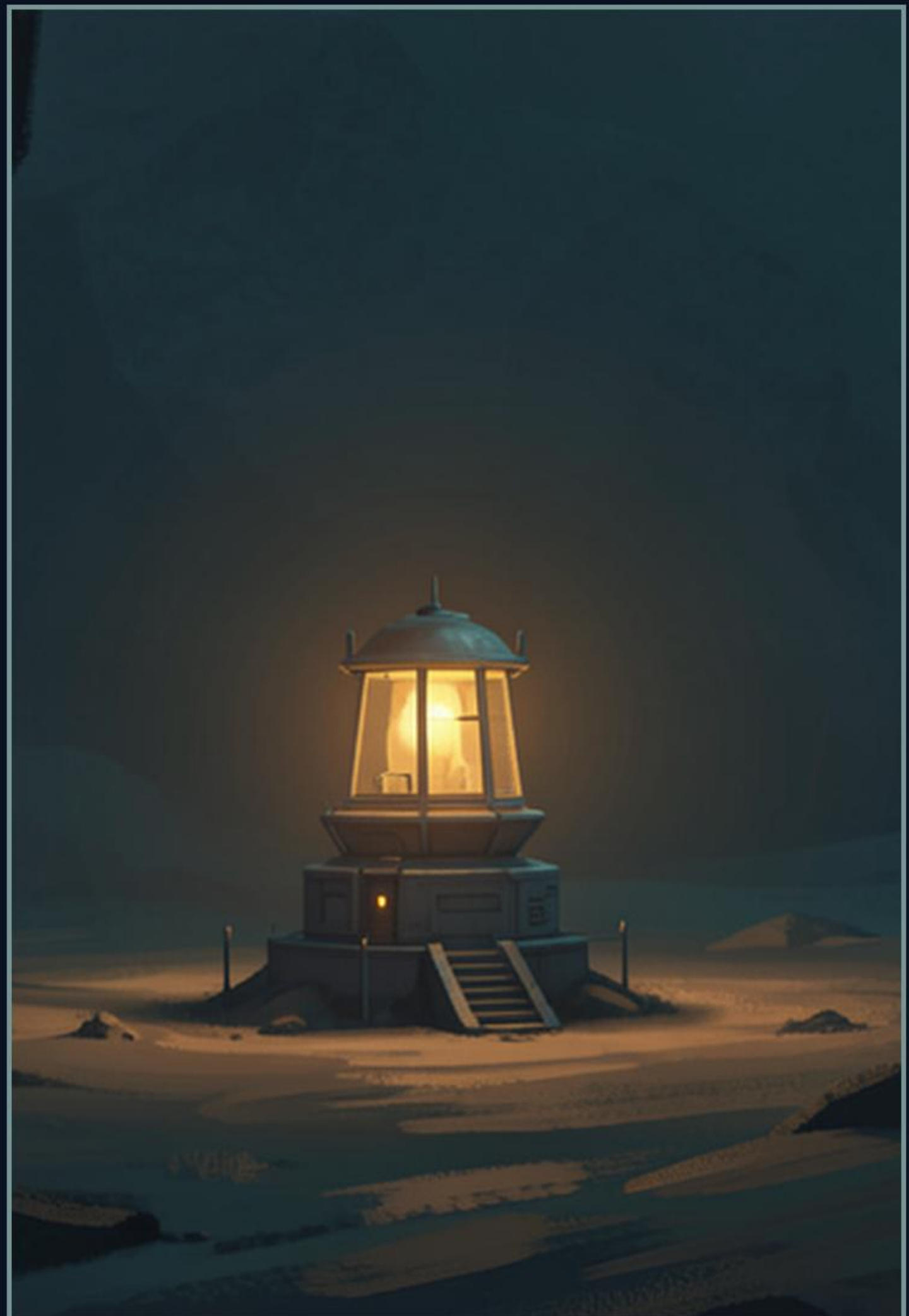
**The Choir's been dark
for a decade.**



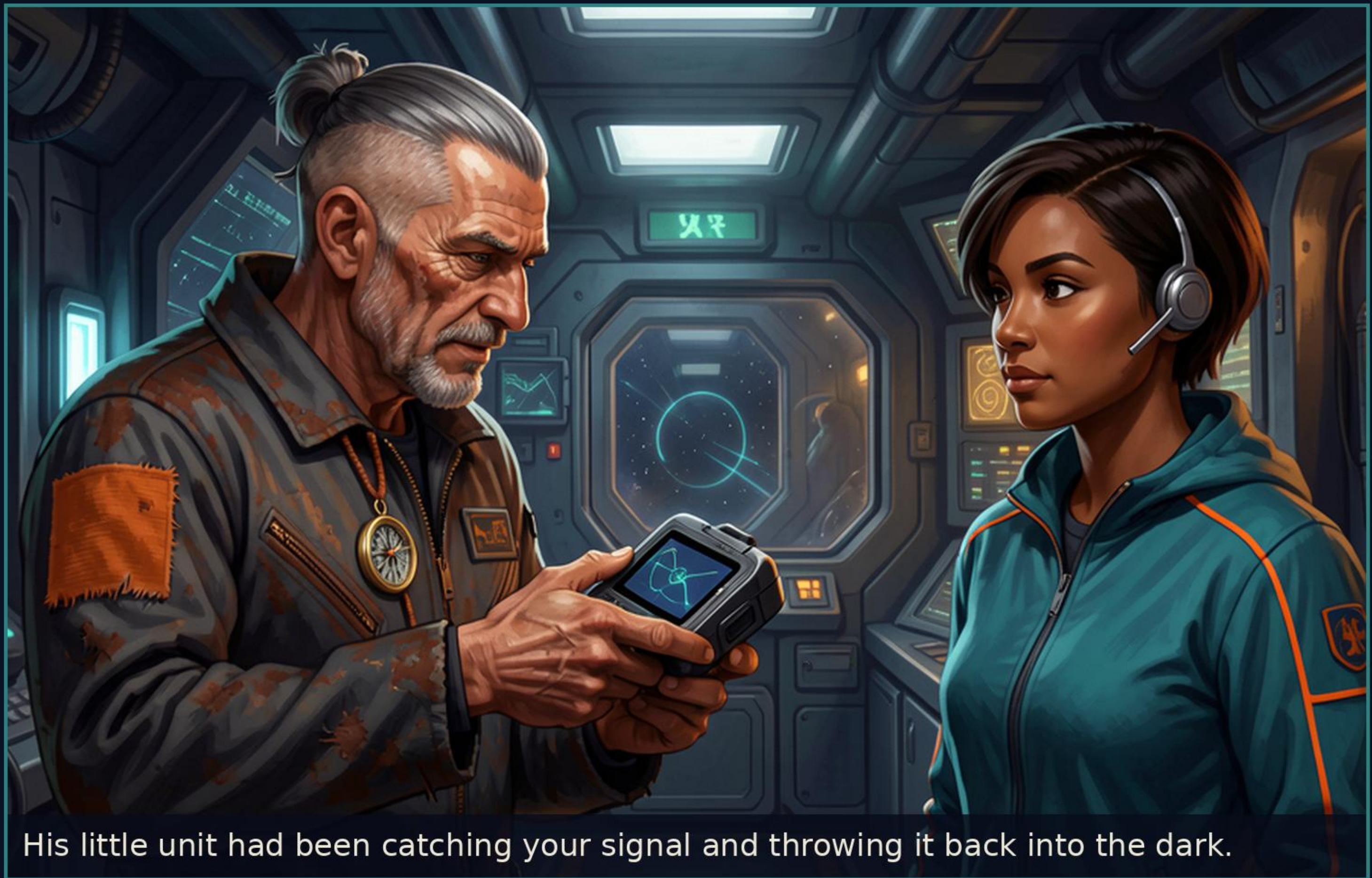
Once there were hundreds. Each a voice. Each a keeper.



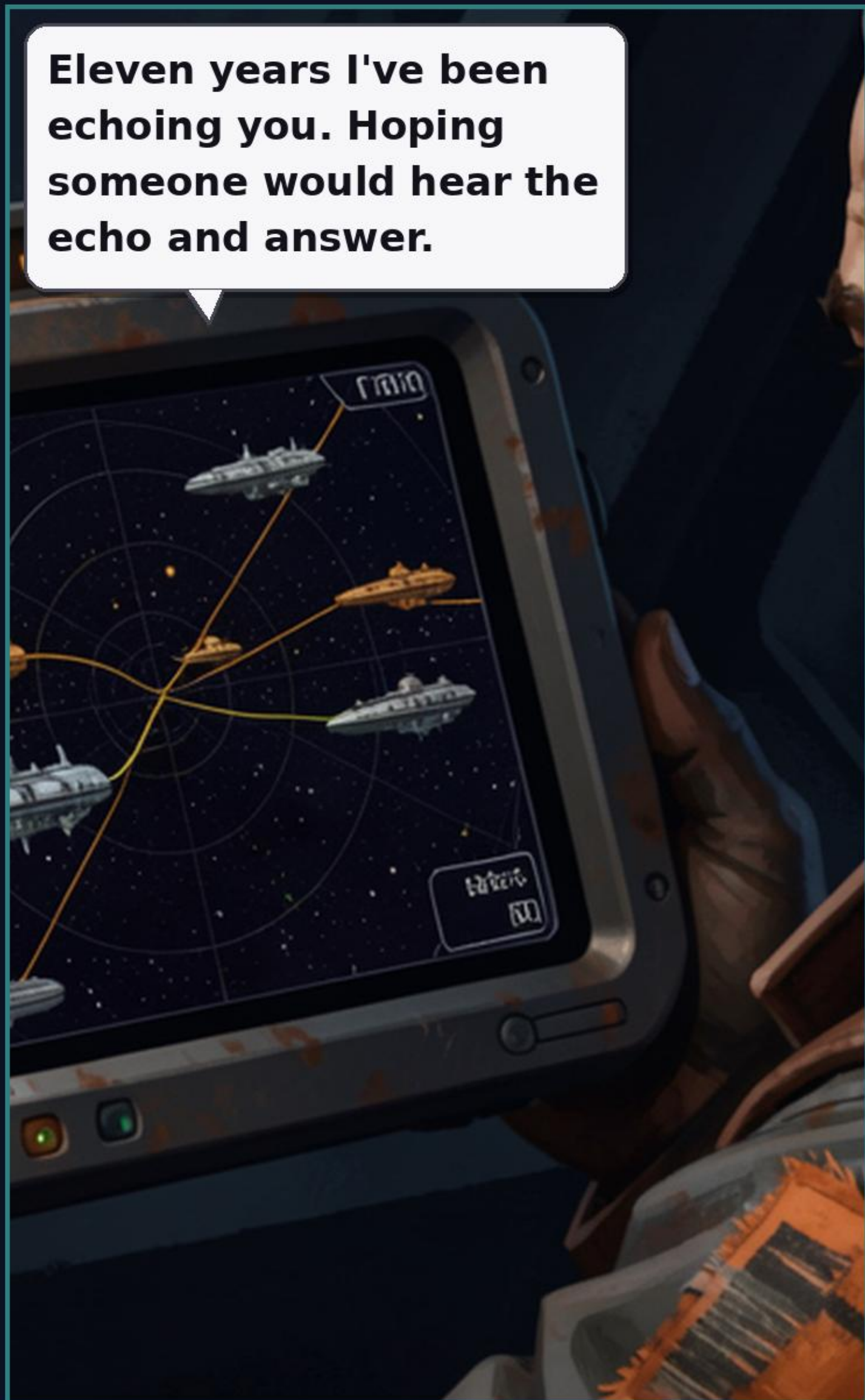
One by one they went dark. Not in war.
In forgetting.



Only Carys kept speaking. You kept
speaking.



His little unit had been catching your signal and throwing it back into the dark.

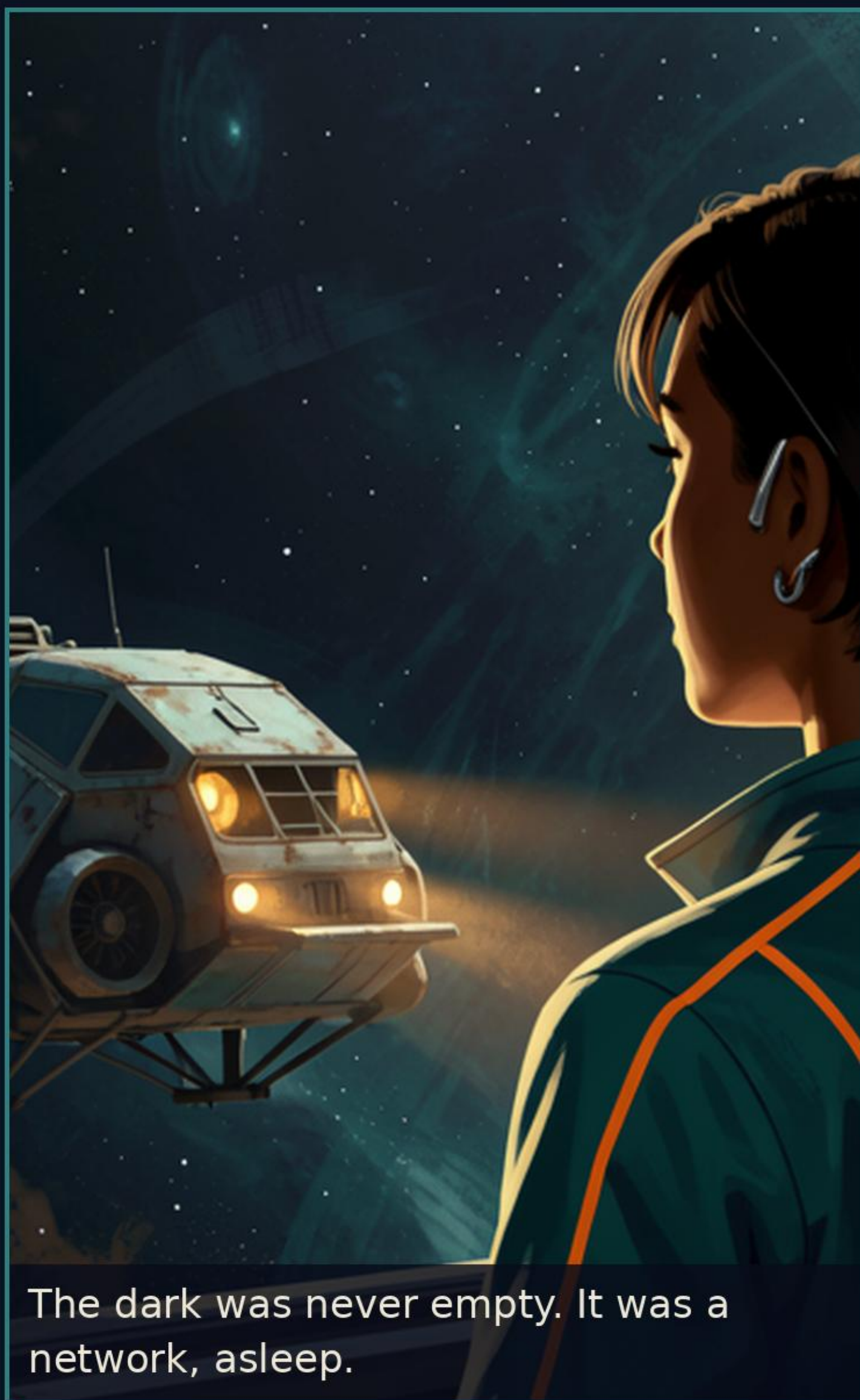


He hadn't found her. He'd been found, by her.

You heard me. All this time.



**Everyone did. No one
had a keeper left to
answer.**



The dark was never empty. It was a network, asleep.

So the census was never a count of nothing.



It was a roll call. And Carys was the only name still answering.

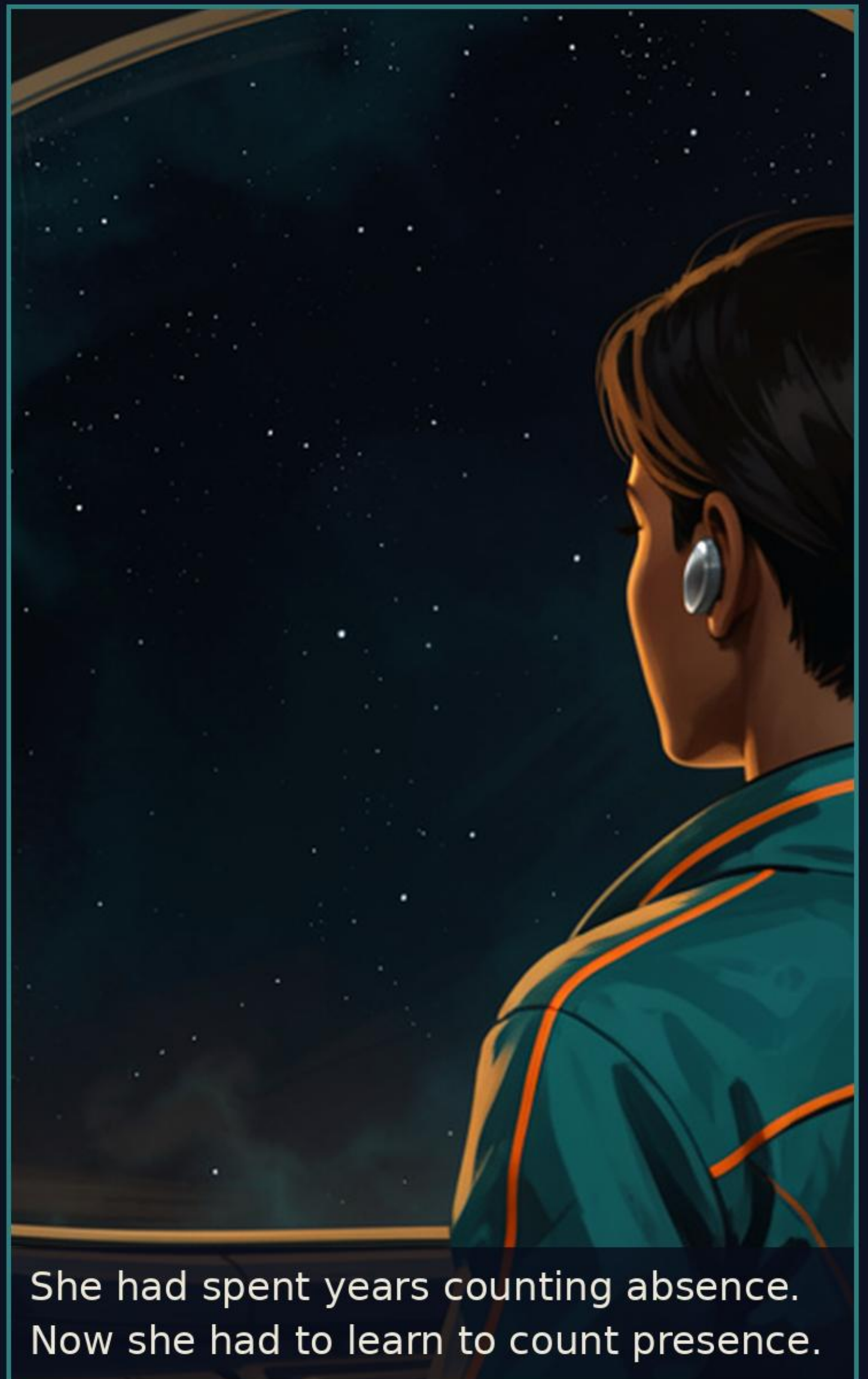


For the first time in eleven years, the silence had a second voice in it.

If they're all dark, what good is one more voice?



One voice is what kept the roll call alive this long.



**She had spent years counting absence.
Now she had to learn to count presence.**



He spread the old chart. Most lights were cold. One was not.

**There. Faint, but alive.
Someone's still at
Meridian.**



**Then we're not the only
two after all.**





She turned Carys's voice toward that faint blink, and waited.

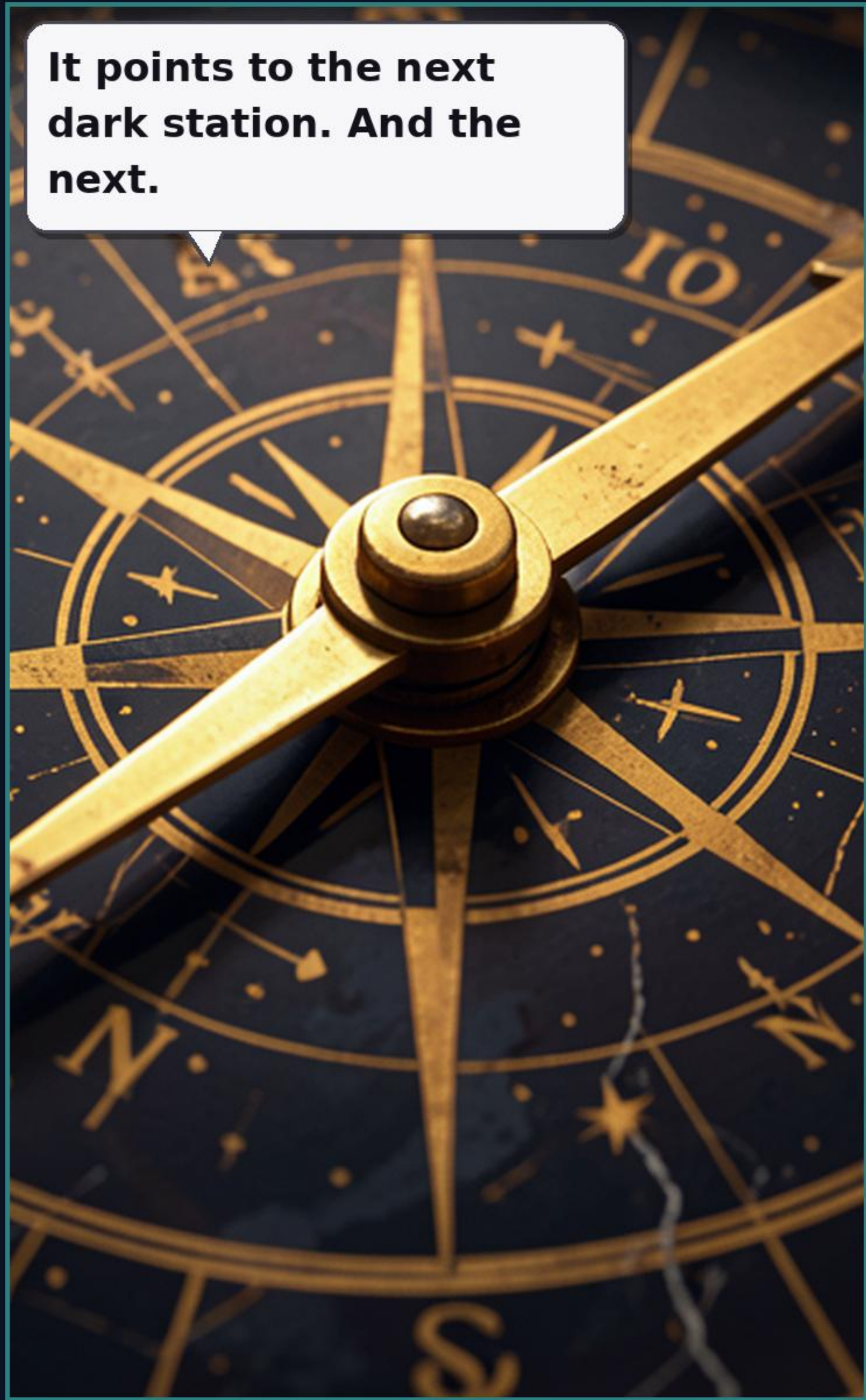
**There. A reply. Small.
Faint. Real.**



Two strangers and a dead network,
breathing in time.



His old compass had stopped meaning anything. Until now.



It points to the next dark station. And the next.



Then we carry the roll call station to station.

One beacon at a time. We
re-light the Choir.



You fly. I keep Carys as
the heart. We meet the
dark together.



Not a rescue. A restoration.

**Day four thousand twenty-two.
If you hear this: you are not the
last.**



**The listening continues.
Outward.**



**He would carry her voice to the next
silent station, and the next.**





"Someone who remembered how to listen." She'd said it of the arrival.



But the Choir had remembered, too. Every one of them, before they went dark.



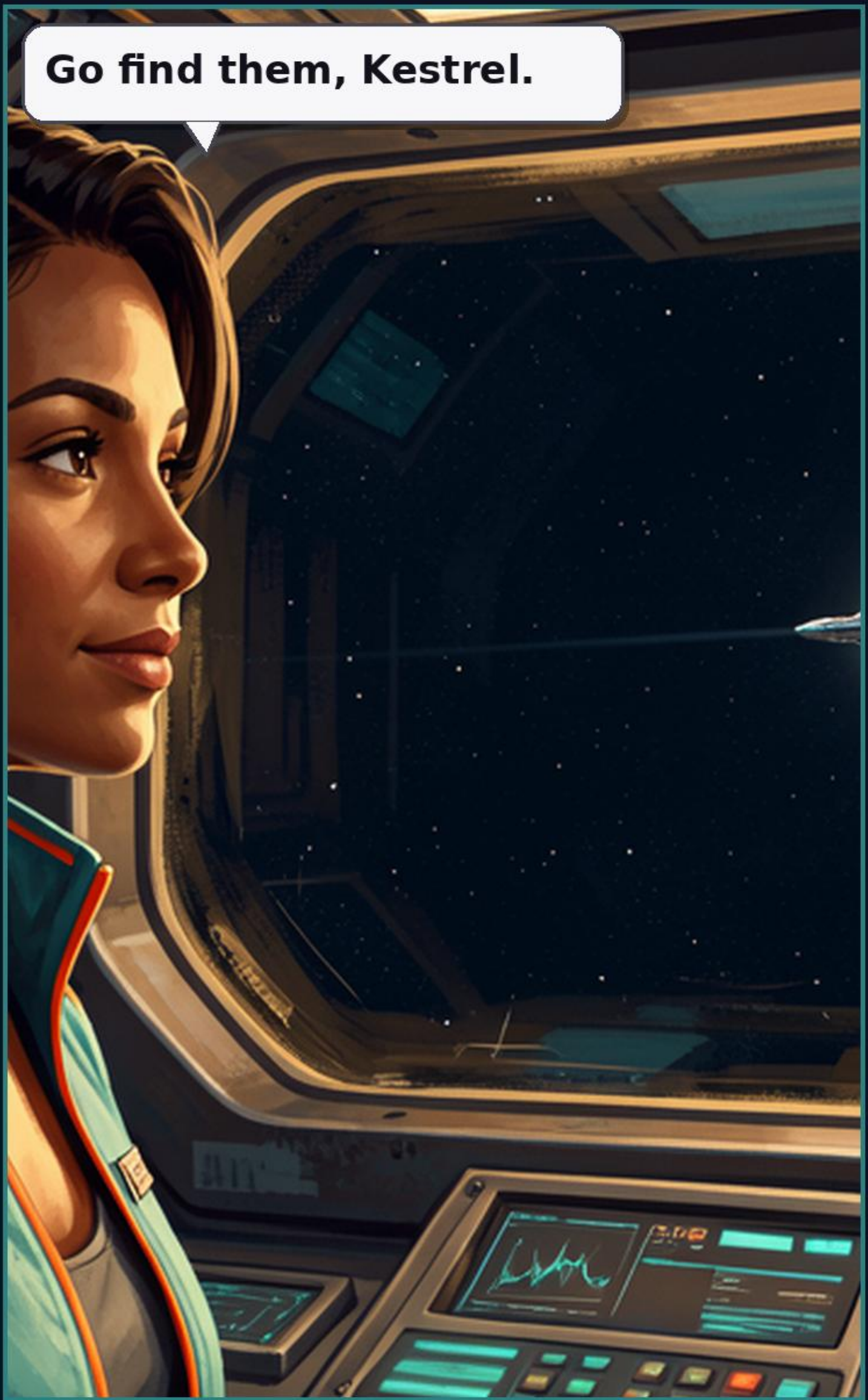
We were never the only ones who listened.



Lantern pulled away. Carys flared — not in grief, but in signal.



Kestrel took her voice outward, along the old Choir roads.



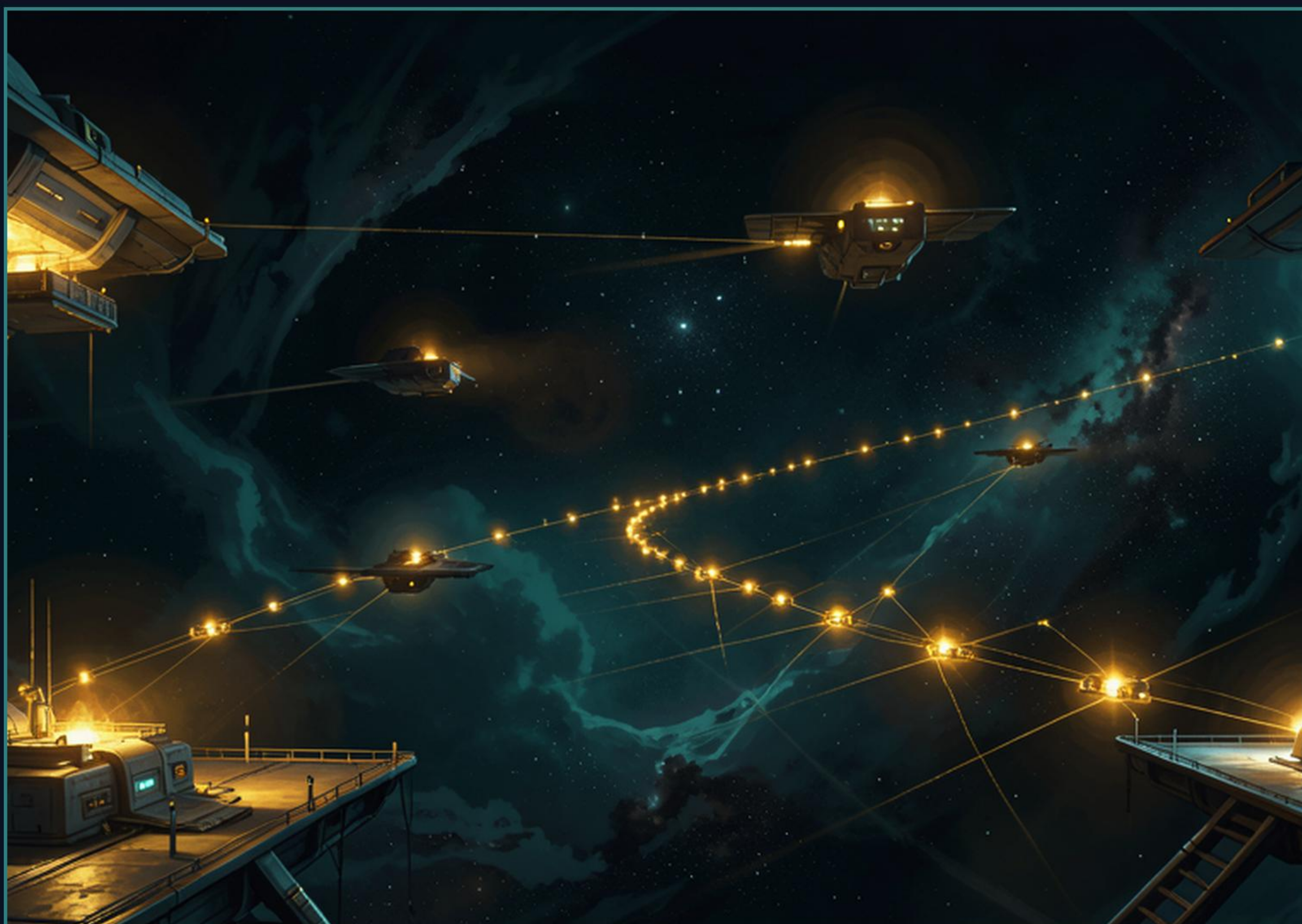
Go find them, Kestrel.



One pulse, sent with intent, crossing the distance that had kept them apart for a decade.



At the edge of everything, a light that had been dark for years opened its eye.



Then another. And another. The Choir, remembering how to answer.

Day four thousand
twenty-three. Census of the
dark: the roll call answers.



She was no longer the last voice. She
was the first the others had heard in
years.



The silence had become a song with
many singers.

Day four thousand
twenty-three. Census of the
dark: the listening resumes.



Outward. The beacon keeps its watch, and the Choir keeps its promise. The listening continues.